

HORIZON-WIDERA-2023-ERA-01-09: Policy support to facilitate the implementation of a zero-tolerance approach towards gender-based violence in the ERA

Specific conditions	
<i>Expected EU contribution per project</i>	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of around EUR 2.00 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and selection of a proposal requesting different amounts.
<i>Indicative budget</i>	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 2.00 million.
<i>Type of Action</i>	Coordination and Support Actions

Expected Outcome: Projects are expected to contribute to the following expected outcomes:

- Support to various national R&I entities, including national administrations, with adopting a zero-tolerance approach towards gender-based violence (GBV), including sexual harassment at higher education institutions and research organisations, in line with the ERA Policy Agenda action 5;
- Cooperation between national R&I actors from Member States and Associated Countries, including with less advanced organisations, to facilitate the exchange of information, mutual learning, and best practice sharing on the implementation of measures to tackle GBV;
- Training and awareness-raising activities for research funding and performing organisations, and other research and innovation actors on how to best implement a zero-tolerance approach towards GBV at their organisation;
- Data collection and monitoring on the implementation of GBV measures at higher education institutions and other research organisations, in line with the Ljubljana Declaration on gender equality in research and innovation.

These targeted outcomes in turn contribute to medium and long-term impacts:

- Research entities in Member States and Associated Countries having measures in place to effectively address cases of gender-based violence, including sexual harassment, and to provide victim support and hold perpetrators accountable;
- Research talents, particularly women and LGBTIQ+ persons, remain in academic careers due to safer, gender-inclusive, and mental health supportive working environments;
- A safe and gender-inclusive higher education and academic sector, benefitting from a strong network and knowledge base on the prevention of and protection from GBV.

Scope: Gender-based violence (GBV), including sexual harassment, sexual assault and psychological violence, occurs at all career levels of higher education and research and in all disciplines. It has destructive consequences for individuals, disrupts careers, damages institutions, and affects the quality of research and education itself. Nevertheless, very few countries have comprehensive policies in place to address the issue, as relatively little public policy attention has been given to GBV in universities and research institutions in the EU.⁶⁸ With the institutional change approach through gender equality plans, measures to address GBV (e.g., through a code of conduct or a protocol for complaints), are expected to advance among R&I organisations, as they are recommended components of these plans, defined in the Horizon Europe eligibility criteria. However, a more comprehensive and strategic policy coordination is needed to ensure that R&I entities in Member States and Associated Countries are supported in implementing the necessary institutional changes to foster safe and inclusive working environments in academia. Interplays between gender-based violence and more

⁶⁸ [ERAC 1205/1/20 REV 1](#): Sexual Harassment in the Research and Higher Education Sector: National Policies and Measures in EU Member States and Associated Countries

subtle forms of psychological violence, such as stress and pressure, often inherent in reward-based and hierarchical systems such as academia, should also be taken into account.

This action should support Member States, Associated Countries, as well as national research funding organisations (RFOs) and research performing organisations (RPOs), with the implementation of a strategic zero-tolerance approach towards gender-based violence in higher education and research. This action should directly contribute to the outcome under the ERA policy agenda, action 5⁶⁹, and support the implementation of EU Presidencies priorities.

During its lifetime, the action should:

- Support the sharing of information, mutual learning, best practice sharing, training, and awareness raising on tackling GBV in academia across Member States, Associated Countries, RPOs and RFOs. Providing support and advancing the knowledge of R&I actors in Widening countries is thereby of particular importance. The action should build on the zero-tolerance policy established by the Communities of Practice, under call topic HORIZON-WIDERA-2021-ERA-01-81;
- Facilitate the implementation of an EU baseline code of conduct on zero-tolerance towards GBV, including sexual harassment, adapted to a wide range of RPOs, including higher education institutions, RFOs and other research organisations in Member States and Associated Countries;
- Foster dialogue, awareness-raising and training to counter more subtle forms of psychological violence, including cases that result from PhD supervisor/PhD candidate, mentor/mentee dependencies, and other forms of hierarchical relationships;
- Particular attention should be given to protection mechanisms for internationally mobile students and researchers, as well as early-career stage researchers in precarious positions;
- Monitor and evaluate the implementation process of the code of conduct on zero-tolerance of GBV at a wide range of higher education institutions, RPOs, RFOs, and other research organisations.

The action should develop close cooperation with relevant R&I stakeholders, including umbrella organisations, share knowledge and evidence, and build on the outputs and recommendations of related actions, e.g., Horizon 2020-SwafS funded UniSAFE⁷⁰ project, the GEAR tool⁷¹, as well as on other key initiatives at national level⁷² and institutional level from

⁶⁹ [ERA Policy Agenda Action 5 outcome](#): “Strategy to counteract gender-based violence including sexual harassment in the European R&I system and to assure gender equality in working environments through institutional change in any research funding or performing organisation”

⁷⁰ <https://unisafe-gbv.eu/>

⁷¹ EIGE’s Gender Equality in Academia and Research tool: <https://eige.europa.eu/gender-mainstreaming/toolkits/gear/action-toolbox>

⁷² See e.g., ERAC 1205/1/20 REV 1, by former ERAC Standing Working Group on Gender in Research and Innovation (SWG GRI): [Sexual Harassment in the Research and Higher Education Sector: National Policies and Measures in EU Member States and Associated Countries](#)